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THE CASTE WARRIORS Former minister Swami Prasad Maurya, Dharam Singh Saini and other MLAs joining the SP (right); BSP chief Mayawati at a press conference in Lucknow, announcing a candidate list for the election

promoted his Yadav community to the exclusion and detriment of non-Yadav OBCs and EBCs. That worked. In 2017, the BJP won 58 per cent of the total non-Yadav OBC votes, besides an inflow of Dalits who previously owed allegiance to Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party.

This time Akhilesh, an engineering graduate, is assembling his own coalition engine. A set of cannily plotted alliances, he hopes, will turbocharge his campaign and put him in pole position. He has with him the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD), which has a large following in the Jat community, the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) of the Rajbhar community, an influential OBC group in eastern UP, and three other smaller parties that have pockets of influence among OBCs and scheduled castes (*see graphic*). SBSP leader Om Prakash Rajbhar, a former minister in the Yogi cabinet who had been ousted in 2019, says: "The BJP has cheated us and now our SP alliance is going to defeat the party. Mark my words, Yogi is going back to Gorakhpur, with the voters chanting '*Chal Sanyasi Mandir Mein*' on March 10." Akhilesh has also patched up with his *chacha* Shivpal Yadav; the younger brother of his father and SP patriarch Mulayam Yadav had split and formed his own party, the Pragatisheel Samaj Party (Lohia) or PSPL. Most importantly, unlike the situation that prevailed during his tenure as CM, Akhilesh has unified the SP under him and demonstrated that now he is his own boss.

THERE IS A METHOD to Akhilesh's reverse-engineering of the BJP strategy that had toppled him in 2017. His own Yadav community forms only some 25-30 per cent of the total OBC vote (the latter is estimated at about 40 per cent of the overall electorate)—the rest come from other castes, many much more deprived. By winning over prominent OBC faces from the BJP and forming alliances with both MBCs and EBCs, he is building the narrative that, overall, the backwards lost out when they allied with the BJP. In doing so, Akhilesh hopes to push his votes from the various OBC communities to around 20-25 per cent. This is over and above his pursuit of anti-incumbency votes with a general (and trenchant) critique of the Adityanath government for non-performance on development, unemployment and price rise.

With Mayawati seemingly dormant in this election, he also hopes to wean away some of the non-Jatav scheduled caste communities from the BSP umbrella. (The Dalits overall account for 20 per cent votes in UP). While Mayawati had successfully cobbled a combination of Dalits, Muslims and Brahmins to win a majority in 2007, that alliance now stands considerably eroded. Ten of the BSP's 17 MLAs, belonging largely to non-Dalit communities, have defected to the Samajwadi camp. BSP spokesperson Faizan Khan, however, argues that Behenji has been working silently to retain her vote base and believes that, come March 10, she will be playing kingmaker.

Akhilesh, meanwhile, is also expecting the 20 per cent Muslim votes to